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Against the Caesarist Crowd: Georges Sorel's Early Democratic Socialism during the Dreyfus Affair

Peter Giraudo 

Core Curriculum, Boston College, Chestnut Hill, MA, USA

Email: peter.giraudo@gmail.com

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This article presents an account of Georges Sorel's socialist theory during the Dreyfus affair. It demonstrates that he developed a theory of the socialist movement in which socialist progress required workers' dissociation from Parisian crowds. The affair showed Sorel that the leaders of the Parti ouvrier français (POF) were Jacobin demagogues who used militarist political organization and press rhetoric to fashion workers into Caesarist crowds. In these crowds, workers acclaimed their leaders as savior figures and blindly followed their suggestions for violence. For Sorel, POF leaders would likely direct crowds as instruments of terror in coup d'états to establish their dictatorship in the state. I contend that Sorel embraced the bourses du travail in the 1890s because their distinctive media and cultural environment constructed a different kind of proletariat. This proletariat pursued a democratic socialism of economic self-government and communicative, coalition-building street action. These institutions thus dissolved Caesarist crowds in French socialism.

Georges Sorel's *Réflexions sur la violence* (1908) gave him a reputation as a thinker who romanticized the proletariat's revolutionary violence. Yet before his embrace of revolutionary syndicalism in 1903, he articulated a theory of the socialist movement which held that violent crowds threatened the possibility for socialist progress. Like many leftist intellectuals concerned with improving workers' lives, Sorel studied the crowd to understand the dangers and benefits of different kinds of working-class street action. By attending to his neglected account of the crowd in the 1890s, we gain new insights into the cultural contexts that foster the emergence of subservient working-class crowd movements. We can also better understand the environments that encourage workers' autonomous street politics. This article analyzes Sorel's anxieties about crowds to explore the conditions under which beneficial forms of working-class street action can emerge.

Witnessing the rise of the mass press in *fin de siècle* France, Sorel worried about workers' subsumption into bourgeois press culture. He thought journalist agitators were bourgeois Jacobins who disseminated stories of heroic, destructive conquest to

foment working-class crowds prone to hysterical overexcitement. These stories played a central role in making crowds suggestible, such that they blindly followed a leader's commands. Sorel believed that crowds' danger lay in their Caesarist character: they would acclaim a military adventurer as a latter-day Caesar and serve as his instruments of terror in a *coup d'état*. In brief, he held that a militarist press was pervasive in France and fashioned Caesarist crowds. His theory of the crowd was different from better-known accounts.

In the late nineteenth century, crowd psychologists described crowds as inherently irrational, susceptible to unconscious suggestion, and driven by bloodlust.¹ In the twentieth century, historians and sociologists challenged this negative view by demonstrating that many crowds in history drew on discursive contexts, such as oral folk traditions, and followed rational patterns of action.² While Sorel engaged with the field of crowd psychology in the 1890s, he advanced a unique perspective by focusing on the media discourses that motivated crowd action. But, unlike later twentieth-century scholars, he thought the webs of meaning that influenced crowds were not independent of the prevailing bourgeois culture. Sorel offers us a new vision of crowds because he neither dismissed them as inherently irrational nor praised them as agents of generative, rational protest. Instead, he specified discursive–organizational conditions under which working-class street action became irrational and a vehicle for violent Caesarism.

Sorel's reflections on the Dreyfus affair led him to elucidate the relationship between crowds and Caesarism. The affair centered on the French general staff and the Jewish captain Alfred Dreyfus. In 1894, a military court convicted Dreyfus of treason for spying on behalf of Germany. It subsequently came to light that the general staff had forged documents to convict him. When the affair climaxed in 1898, the public was divided between nationalists who supported the army and Dreyfusards who demanded a retrial. Jules Guesde's Parti ouvrier français (POF) announced its neutrality on the trial, effectively aligning it with the anti-Dreyfusards. As passions exploded over the affair, Paris witnessed "the rise in the power of crowds ... the street completed the public space that the press constituted."³ Sorel developed his account of Caesarism in light of the mass boulevard press that emerged in the 1890s and contributed to crowds' paroxysms during the affair.⁴

¹Susanna Barrows, *Distorting Mirrors: Visions of the Crowd in Late Nineteenth-Century France* (New Haven, 1981), 73–92, 114–36.

²George Rudé, *The Crowd in the French Revolution* (Oxford, 1959); E. P. Thompson, "The Moral Economy of the English Crowd in the Eighteenth Century," *Past & Present* 50 (1971), 76–136; Charles Tilly, *Popular Contention in Britain, 1750–1830* (Cambridge, 1995). For recent scholarship in this tradition see Ian Radforth, "Playful Crowds and the 1886 Toronto Street Railway Strikes," *Labour/Le Travail* 76 (2015), 133–64. For an instructive overview of the historiography on crowds see Nicholas Rodgers, *Crowds, Culture, and Politics in Georgian Britain* (Oxford, 1998), 1–20.

³Christophe Prochasson, "Paris au temps de l'affaire Dreyfus," in Vincent Duclert and Perrine Simon-Nahum, eds., *L'affaire Dreyfus: Les événements fondateurs* (Paris, 2009), 220–32, at 220–21.

⁴Jean-Yves Mollier, "La 'littérature du trottoir' à la Belle Époque entre contestation et dérision," *Cahiers d'histoire: Revue d'histoire critique* 90–91 (2003), at <https://doi.org/10.4000/chrhc.1459> (accessed 7 May 2025), 1–11.

To him, the affair showed Caesarism to be a form of mass democracy in which bourgeois, demagogic journalists adopted Jacobinism's militarist political organization and rhetoric to transform workers into manipulable crowds.⁵ Nationalism and Guesdism, he claimed, were revolutionary movements that manifested a Jacobin Caesarism which participated in boulevard press culture: run by journalistic general staffs, these movements wielded centralized mass presses to distribute vulgar legends of conquest against alleged national enemies during elections.⁶ Influenced by his study of the Salpêtrière school of hypnosis in France, Sorel argued that inundation with these legends led workers to enter a state of hysteria and compulsively fixate their attention on leaders as Caesar savior figures. This hysterical state made workers in crowds suggestible and prone to following manipulative leaders into coups. Unlike Karl Marx, Sorel did not view Caesarism as a weak politics that would disappear with the Second Empire once citizens recognized their material oppression under Napoleon III.⁷ Instead, the bourgeoisie's Jacobinism and use of a mass militarist press to beguile workers made Caesarism an enduring threat in the Third Republic.

In viewing press-constructed crowds as vehicles of Caesarism, Sorel operated on the terrain established by the independent, non-party-aligned socialists Gustave Rouanet and Eugène Fournière rather than the crowd psychologists. These figures were editors of the *Revue socialiste* and vocal Dreyfusards.⁸ By examining Sorel's theory of the crowd and his intellectual proximity to these figures, this article provides a new perspective on his thought.⁹ I argue that Sorel's theory of the crowd was a unique contribution to the

⁵On Sorel's lifelong opposition to Jacobinism see Jeremy Jennings, *Revolution and the Republic: A History of Political Thought in France since the Eighteenth Century* (Oxford, 2011), 425–9.

⁶Sorel's thought provides a new angle on Caesarism. Scholarship on Caesarist regimes emphasizes their press censorship rather than wielding of the press to fashion subservient crowds. See Peter Baehr and Melvin Richter, "Introduction," in Baehr and Richter, eds., *Dictatorship in History and Theory: Bonapartism, Caesarism, and Totalitarianism* (Cambridge, 2004), 1–26, at 7. For articulations of the idea of Jacobin Caesarism during the Third Republic see Peter Baer, *Caesar and the Fading of the Roman World: A Study in Republicanism and Caesarism* (London, 1998), 129–31. Baer focuses on the Italian historian Guglielmo Ferrero's use of the concept. Sorel read and corresponded with Ferrero.

⁷For his objection to Marx's view of Caesarism in *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte* see Georges Sorel, "Alcune previsioni storiche di Marx," *Rivista popolare di politica, lettere, e scienze sociali* 6/8 (1900), 147–8, at 147. Sorel's view of Caesarism also differed from Antonio Gramsci's. Gramsci thought that Caesarism's military element became less important with the rise of party-political forces in mass democracy. On Marx and Gramsci's theories see Baehr, *Caesar and the Fading of the Roman World*, 133–48, 265–70.

⁸Étienne Rouanet, "Gustave Rouanet, un publiciste et parlementaire socialiste dans le moment anti-sémite français (1897–1898)," *Cahiers Jaurès* 1/227–8 (2018), 67–91; Emmanuel Jousse, *Les hommes révoltés: Les origines intellectuelles du réformisme en France* (Paris, 2017), 172–94, 220–30; Christophe Portalez, "La revue socialiste face à la corruption politique: Du scandale de Panama à l'affaire Rochette," *Cahiers Jaurès* 3/209 (2013), 15–32; Julian Wright, "Socialism and Political Identity: Eugène Fournière and Intellectual Militancy in the Third Republic," *French Historical Studies* 36/3 (2013), 449–78; Wright, *Socialism and the Experience of Time in Modern France* (Oxford, 2017), 57–63, 84–6.

⁹Scholarship on the early Sorel has focused on his reappraisal of Marxism and not on his theory of the crowd and Caesarism. See Jeremy Jennings, *Georges Sorel: The Character and Development of his Thought* (London, 1985), 37–82; Eric Brandom and Tommaso Giordani, "Introduction: Georges Sorel's Study on Vico in French and European Context," in Brandom and Giordani, eds., *Georges Sorel's Study on Vico* (Leiden, 2020), 1–48.

independent challenge to Guesdism. Scholars have stressed that independent socialists opposed Guesdism because it espoused a dogmatic Marxism that generated authoritarian party discipline.¹⁰ They have also shown that the independents championed a present-minded socialism which held that workers developed a new morality and culture in everyday experiences in cooperative associations.¹¹ The independents consequently opposed the POF's revolutionary millenarianism.¹² My centering of Sorel's worries about crowds shifts the perspective on the problem with Guesdism, while offering new insights into a present-minded socialism's cultural environment and street actions.

I show that Sorel thought that the sources of socialist authoritarianism in Guesdism went beyond dogmatic Marxism: they also lay in a Jacobin militarist party and press culture that fashioned Caesarist crowds.¹³ My account further demonstrates that he saw crowds as conduits of millenarianism: they constructed an idealized revolutionary future on the basis of propaganda legends and sought to violently accelerate into this future. For Sorel, workers needed to inhabit a media and cultural environment fundamentally different from that of Guesdism to become a democratically self-governing, present-minded proletarian subject. He thought the *bourses du travail*, which were federations of trade unions emerging in the 1890s, created this alternative media and cultural setting.

These institutions developed a socialist culture of attentive reflection in contrast to Guesdism's culture of hysterical overexcitement and blind obedience. In the *bourses*,

¹⁰For Charles Andler's critique of Guesdism along these lines see Christophe Prochasson, "Sur la réception du marxisme en France: Le cas Andler (1890–1920)," *Revue de synthèse* 4/1 (1989), 85–108; and Prochasson, "Comment être socialiste? Introduction à *La civilisation socialiste*," in Charles Andler, *La civilisation socialiste* (Lormont, 2010), 9–63, at 37–42. On Fournière and Andler's similar critiques see Wright, "Socialism and Political Identity," 461–4, 470–72. In an important analysis of the independents' view of socialist unity, Jousse has underscored that they sought "to maintain a volatility of [socialist] opinions" in the face of Guesdism's Marxist rigidity. This was a unity based on a "procedural ethic" of open discussion. Jousse, *Les hommes révoltés*, 204, 381. On the independent-minded unionist Albert Thomas's understanding of Guesdism as a "simple political doctrine" too focused on party and power see Gilles Candar, "Albert Thomas et la constitution des réseaux: Les années 1878–1914," *Cahiers Irice* 2/2 (2008), 53–64, at 61.

¹¹See Wright, *Socialism and the Experience of Time*, 21–37. On the independents' "morality of action" and advocacy of present reform through cooperative associations see Christophe Prochasson, "Nouveaux regards sur le réformisme," *Mil neuf cent: Revue d'histoire intellectuelle* 1/30 (2012), 5–20, at 15. See also Candar, "Albert Thomas," 61; and Jousse *Les hommes révoltés*, 382–8.

¹²For examples of Guesdist millenarianism see Jean-Numa Ducange, *Jules Guesde* (Paris, 2017), 56–7, 73–4.

¹³While interpreters have analyzed Sorel's account of authoritarian socialist demagoguery in elections, they have not examined this aspect of it. See Jeremy Jennings, *Syndicalism in France: A Study of Ideas* (London, 1990), 59–61; Brandom and Giordani, "Introduction," 33–5. My account of Sorel complements Prochasson and Candar's wider analyses of socialist literary and art criticism at this time. According to Prochasson, socialists opposed bourgeois literature's "ornamentality" and "artificialness"—and he references a socialist critic's contempt for "ornamental" militarist imagery. See Christophe Prochasson, "Comment imaginer en politique? Images et imagination socialistes au temps de Jaurès," *Cahiers Jaurès* 1/231–2 (2019), 149–62, at 150–51; and Gilles Candar, "De la politique à la littérature? *La petite république* et la critique littéraire," *Romantisme* 33 (2003), 71–9. Sorel's analyses also challenge the claim that "the newspaper public is a democratic and rational taming of the crowd." Jacques Juillard, "Foule, public, opinion: Introduction," *Mil neuf cent: Revue d'histoire intellectuelle* 1/28 (2010), 7–12, at 11.

unionists established a practically oriented union press, studied their local economic context, and engaged in democratic deliberation.¹⁴ These unionists' attentiveness to present possibilities for economic self-government inoculated them from the crowd's pathologies.¹⁵ Their socialist culture ultimately engendered a form of street action different from that of crowds. Sorel emphasized the significance of the nonviolent Dreyfusard street marches conducted by the Allemanist *bourse* unionists.¹⁶ These marches embodied reflective, present-minded socialist action: they activated other citizens' rational faculties by concentrating attention on the Caesarist threat and its democratic socialist alternatives. Through the marches, unionists exercised independent influence in parliamentary democracy and promoted socialist progress: they helped form a republican–socialist coalition and inspired socialist representation committed to facilitating union self-government. Sorel initially viewed the new cabinet of 1899 in this light.

The early Sorel's analyses of the Third Republic's mass democracy underscored the dangers that militarist party organization and press rhetoric pose to socialism.¹⁷ The more the socialist movement organizes centralized propaganda premised on narratives of destructive conquest, the more workers become a manipulable crowd prone to Caesarism and incapable of self-government. The path to a democratic socialism of self-government, Sorel insisted, lies in establishing media and cultural settings, along with street actions, where workers substitute practices of directed attention for dreams of revolutionary conquest.¹⁸

A mirror of militarist nationalism: the independents' critique of Guesdism

In the 1890s, the independent socialists advanced a critique of Guesdism's authoritarian character. They claimed that the rise of nationalism after the 1870–71 Franco-Prussian War and during the Boulangist crisis of 1887–9 contributed to the development of an authoritarian relationship between leader and mass in the movement. This was because many demagogic, nationalist journalists who had supported

¹⁴On French socialism's educational culture at this time see Christophe Prochasson, *Le socialisme, une culture* (Paris, 2009), 36–44. For reflections on the “practices” unique to working-class culture see Marion Fontaine, “Introduction,” *Mil neuf cent: Revue d'histoire intellectuelle* 1/35 (2017), 9–17, at 16.

¹⁵The *bourses'* function as anti-crowd institutions is left out of the otherwise excellent Eric Brandom, “Against the Hierarchy of Knowledge: Georges Sorel, Education, and Revolution,” *French History* 37/1 (2023), 53–70.

¹⁶On the Allemanists' socialist Dreyfusardism see Madeleine Rebérioux, “Le socialisme français de 1871–1914,” in Jacques Droz, ed., *Histoire générale du socialisme*, 4 vols. (Paris, 1983), 2: 133–236, at 183–5; and Vincent Duclert, “À la recherche de la nouvelle affaire Dreyfus? Les socialistes français, la politique et l'histoire,” *Cahiers Jaurès* 1/187–8 (2008), 117–28.

¹⁷Sorel's account suggests that historians should reassess whether socialist authoritarian party building only emerged after World War I. For this view see Ducange, *Jules Guesde*, 116.

¹⁸Sorel was part of the French tradition that advocated for a decentralized republic against the centralized Jacobin state. See H. S. Jones and Julian Wright, “A Pluralist History of France?,” in Jones and Wright, eds., *Pluralism and the Idea of the Republic in France* (London, 2012), 1–22. Sorel called Rouanet and Fournière “[French] socialism's greatest representatives” because they defended this decentralized democratic socialism. Georges Sorel, “Les congrès ouvriers de France,” *Le pays de France* 1 (1899), 418–30, at 425.

General Ernest Boulanger's movement against France's parliamentary republic joined Guesdism after Boulangism's collapse. These were the journalists and boulevard hawkers whose mass distribution of political newspapers, brochures, and placards generated the "war of paper" during Boulangism and the Dreyfus affair.¹⁹ They gave the Parisian "street a function that it had not previously fulfilled" and became "the driving force of crowds."²⁰ The independents believed that, by pushing militarist street literature of heroic conquest against the corrupt "Jewish" republic, these journalists transformed much of the Parisian public into suggestible Caesarist crowds. For them, since Guesde tolerated this Boulangist remnant's entry into the POE, its propaganda had similar effects on workers in the movement.²¹

The Boulangist campaign emerged due to the transformation of patriotic sentiments after the Franco-Prussian War. "The German annexation of Alsace-Lorraine," Fournière explained in 1902, "was the cause of our patriotism's evolution into nationalism."²² Public schools after 1871 spread "the vile lead of bellicose nationalism."²³ For example, the minister of public education, Jules Ferry, required schools to distribute 20,000 copies of the *Chants du soldat*—virulent patriotic poems written by the nationalist leader, Paul Déroulède.²⁴ The Boulangist movement was the first political expression of this new nationalism. Bearing the slogan "Dissolution, revision, constituent assembly," Boulangism aimed to revise the constitution to end parliamentarism and install Boulanger as a presidential dictator. A presidential dictator's unitary executive power—in contrast to parliament's indecisiveness—would make a successful revanchist war possible.

In an 1888 essay, Fournière highlighted how "the noisiest and most active group" in Boulangism "is recruited among the plunderers [*écumeurs*] of the press and the boulevard."²⁵ These boulevard journalists "took advantage of the revival of warlike ideas" to "seduce the crowd with colored images ... naive placards, silly songs, mystical adulations, and tales."²⁶ By depicting Boulanger as a heroic warrior in caricatured placards, stories, and hymns, they prompted a general discontent with the present and evoked

¹⁹Jean-Yves Mollier, "Zola et la rue," *Les cahiers naturalistes* 44/72 (1998), 75–91, at 77. See also the book-length treatment of this subject: Jean-Yves Mollier, *Le Camelot et la rue: Politique et démocratie au tournant des XIXe et XXe siècles* (Paris, 2004).

²⁰Mollier, "La 'littérature du trottoir,'" 4, 9.

²¹For discussions of Rouanet's view of the boulevard press that nonetheless neglect his worry about Caesarism see Portalez, "La Revue socialiste," 15–32; and Rouanet, "Gustave Rouanet," 67–91. On the independents' opposition to Boulangism see Michel Winock, "Socialism and Boulangism, 1887–89," in Edward Arnold, ed., *The Development of the Radical Right in France* (London, 2000), 3–15, at 3–4, 10–14. Jousse does not center the boulevard press in his analysis of the independents' rejection of Boulangism. Jousse, *Les hommes révoltés*, 149–57.

²²Eugène Fournière, "Le nationalisme (lettre à M. Jules Soury)," *Revue socialiste* 36/211 (1902), 1–30, at 14.

²³*Ibid.*, 11.

²⁴Zeev Sternhell, *La droite révolutionnaire: Les origines françaises du fascisme, 1885–1914* (Paris, 1978), 79–83.

²⁵Benoît Malon and Eugène Fournière, "Physiologie du boulangisme," *Revue socialiste* 7/41 (1888), 507–21, at 519.

²⁶*Ibid.*, 514, 510.

hope for redemption from France's oppression. In Boulanger, the crowd saw a "heroic, Cornelian attitude and the aureole of the predestined [savior]."²⁷ Rouanet developed this account of Boulangist propaganda by tying it to crowd suggestion:

the irresistible suggestion that one exerts on crowds [occurs] through the incessant repetition of ideas ... Boulanger's popularity consisted in the profusion of images, portraits, photographs, engravings, spread everywhere, *violently attracting attention*, forcing the eyes to retain the idol's features in all forms—portrait or caricature. Through the daily publication of thousands of newspaper articles, [the crowd was] delivered to a permanent suggestive action.²⁸

Boulangist mass propaganda thus disabled much of the Parisian public's capacity to direct its attention elsewhere: it made the public *obsessed* with Boulanger as the *général revanche* who would restore national honor. The crowd's obsessive state made it open to the "Boulangist suggestion [that a new regime could be] obtained through violent means."²⁹

For the independents, nationalist press demagoguery intensified during the Dreyfus affair, particularly in 1897–8. In the fall, investigative work by Dreyfus's brother revealed that the primary piece of evidence used by the general staff to convict Dreyfus was a forgery. Calls for a revised trial from the vice president of the Senate and Dreyfusards ensued. Émile Zola's publication of *J'accuse* in January 1898 was the most important: it castigated the general staff for its lies, President Félix Faure for supporting anti-Semitism, and the government for failing to pursue revision. These accusations generated a violent response from the nationalist press which "intoxicated public opinion" such that it "permanently refused to recognize the obvious."³⁰ Boulevard journalists and their hawkers flooded the street with ever greater amounts of printed material to defend the general staff.³¹ In this context, the independents argued that nationalist journalism manipulated the public to embrace a new Caesar: the chief of the general staff, Raoul de Boisdeffre.

First, they argued that the nationalist press overwhelmed the public with wild speculations about Dreyfus's reasons for spying on behalf of Germany: the aim was to inflame Parisians' feelings of hatred towards him and the Jews as "internal enemies."³² Second, they maintained that the press portrayed Boisdeffre and the general staff as wrongly persecuted outlaws fighting to save France from the Jewish threat. Rouanet stressed that "*L'Écho de Paris*, *Le Gil Blas* ... *La Patrie* and *La Presse* ... distort facts ... duped by stories of bandits, [the reader embraces] nationalist opinions."³³ These stories of heroic banditry constituted the "Caesarist demagoguery" that led Parisians to

²⁷ Ibid., 517.

²⁸ Gustave Rouanet, *Les complicités du Panama: Pages d'histoire sociale contemporaine* (Paris, 1893), 1–2, added emphasis.

²⁹ Ibid., 2.

³⁰ Bertrand Joly, *Histoire politique de l'affaire Dreyfus* (Paris, 2014), 193, 192.

³¹ The distribution of printed material peaked in 1898. Mollier, "La 'littérature du trottoir,'" 4.

³² Gustave Rouanet, "Nouveaux brouillards," *La petite provençal* 23/7760 (1898), 1.

³³ Gustave Rouanet, "Les élections de Paris et le parti socialiste," *Revue socialiste* 31/186 (1900), 716–32, at 724.

fixate their attention on Boisdeffre as the figure who would ensure “national salvation.”³⁴ Much of the public consequently formed suggestible crowds prone to violence. These crowds manifested their violent tendencies in response to Zola’s *J’accuse*. Indeed, for the independents, the nationalist press caused crowds’ anti-Semitic rioting in Paris in the weeks and months after Zola’s intervention.³⁵ “Boulevard journalists,” Fournière warned, “swell crowds’ crazy panics and transform citizens into a herd of brutes rushing under the butcher’s knife.”³⁶ As one historian emphasizes, mass pamphlets’ “symbolic execution of the enemy” with headlines like “Down with the Jews!” encouraged physical violence.³⁷ Yet, if the independents worried about crowds following the general staff into a coup, they did not see the threat of Caesarism as confined to the nationalist right.

In their view, the migration of ex-Boulangist journalists to French socialism resulted in the spread of militarist press demagoguery within the movement: in the 1890s “a mass of discontented people, who confused aimless agitation with fruitful action, demagoguery with democracy, adorned themselves with the socialist label without professing its doctrine ... they were former Boulangists who had preserved Boulangism’s demagogic temperament. Socialism, for them, was an irrational opposition.”³⁸ These journalists joined either the Blanquist Comité central socialiste révolutionnaire (CCSR), led by Ernest Roche and Ernest Granger who had supported Boulanger, or the POF.³⁹ The anti-Semitic editor of *L’Intransigeant*, Henri Rochefort, epitomized this Boulangist remnant’s demagogic, anti-Semitic journalism.⁴⁰

The POF’s shift to a position of neutrality on the Dreyfus affair in 1898 facilitated the ex-Boulangists’ demagoguery because it licensed their use of anti-Semitic stories of conquest in canvassing for the party.⁴¹ During the 1900 Parisian municipal election, for example, Rouanet claimed that “the nationalist intrigue disorients Parisian socialists” because there are “certain individuals with shady designs [who] adapt their revolutionary rhetoric to nationalism’s demagogic declamation system.”⁴² This was a reference to the Boulangist remnant inundating workers with stories that depicted Guesde as the new Caesar who would save France from Jewish capital. As a result, workers became obsessed and formed unthinking Caesarist crowds: “Guesde has within the worker groups ... people who obey him at his fingertips and passionate admirers who believe

³⁴Gustave Rouanet, “La question juive,” *Revue socialiste* 29/169 (1899), 78–97, at 96.

³⁵See Stephen Wilson, “The Antisemitic Riots of 1898 in France,” *Historical Journal* 16/4 (1973), 789–806.

³⁶Eugène Fournière, “Au combat, à la victoire!”, *La Lanterne* 23/8118 (1900), 1.

³⁷Mollier, “La ‘littérature du trottoir,’” 2.

³⁸Gustave Rouanet, “Le Parti socialiste française en 1898,” *Revue socialiste* 28/163 (1898), 91–106, at 93, 95–6.

³⁹See Claude Willard, *Les guesdistes: Le mouvement socialiste en France, 1893–1905* (Paris, 1965), 88–9.

⁴⁰Eugène Fournière, “Le nationalisme (lettre à M. Jules Soury) (suite),” *Revue socialiste* 36/213 (1902), 257–89, at 276. On Rochefort’s closeness to the CCSR see Michel Winock, “Rochefort: La Commune contre Dreyfus,” *Mil neuf cent: Revue d’histoire intellectuelle* 11 (1993), 82–6.

⁴¹See Gilles Candar, “Jules Guesde, le combat manqué,” *Mil neuf cent: Revue d’histoire intellectuelle* 11 (1993), 50–55, at 52.

⁴²Gustave Rouanet, “Le congrès de Lyon,” *Revue socialiste* 33/198 (1901), 654–74, at 672. On the Guesdists’ anti-Semitic rhetoric see Stephen Wilson, *Ideology and Experience: Antisemitism in France at the Time of the Dreyfus Affair* (Oxford, 2007), 336.

everything he tells them.”⁴³ A Guesdist coup was possible because workers “abdicated their thought before leaders hungry for dictatorship.”⁴⁴ For the independents, then, Guesdism contributed to the threat of Caesarist militarism gripping France in the 1890s.

The independents nevertheless believed that workers’ organization outside the POF served as bulwark against boulevard journalism and military adventurism. They saw the “Allemanists” as “leading the defense campaign against neo-Boulangism in 1898–99.”⁴⁵ These socialist unionists were helping to “cure Paris of plumes and shady adventurers.”⁴⁶ Like the independents, Sorel worried about press-constructed Caesarist crowds and the possibility of military dictatorship during the Dreyfus affair; he too praised the Allemanists’ vigorous opposition to the Caesarist threat. Yet, as a former civil engineer interested in scientific scholarship, Sorel developed a theory of the crowd via a different route than the independents. While his historical inquiry into Jacobinism in 1888–9 also spoke to the Boulangist moment, his subsequent intellectual engagement with experimental psychology led him to advance a novel view of crowd suggestion. This view would underpin his concern about the press’s influence on crowds during the affair.

Sorel’s theory of crowd suggestion

Sorel’s first public writings evinced a hostility to the French bourgeoisie for its embrace of the Jacobin revolutionary tradition and dictatorial tendencies.⁴⁷ In studies of the Jacobin army’s actions in southern France in 1792–3, Sorel highlighted Jacobinism’s militarist rhetoric. In these texts from 1888–9, he explored issues raised by Boulangism because he focused on nationalist, militarist legends’ influence on Jacobin soldiers. These historical investigations need to be read alongside Sorel’s writings on experimental psychology at the time. This is because he developed an account of Jacobin literature that he connected to the understanding of crowd suggestion which he gained from experimental psychology.

The psychologists Jean-Martin Charcot and Hippolyte Bernheim’s pioneering studies of hypnosis in the 1880s were touchstones of much analysis of mass democratic society in France and Italy at the *fin de siècle*. Many intellectuals concerned with the phenomenon of crowds in this period adopted a hypnotic paradigm to explain crowd behavior.⁴⁸ Crowd psychologists Gabriele Tarde, Scipio Sighele, Cesare Lombroso, and Gustave Le Bon all examined crowd movements from this perspective. These figures followed Bernheim’s Nancy school in viewing hypnotic suggestion as a universal phenomenon that did not require any specific mental preconditions: all individuals in

⁴³ Gustave Rouanet, “Les deux congrès de 1900,” *Revue socialiste* 32/190 (1900), 460–96, at 469.

⁴⁴ Gustave Rouanet, “Le congrès de 1900,” *Revue socialiste* 32/189 (1900), 318–46, at 340.

⁴⁵ Gustave Rouanet, “La crise du parti socialiste (suite),” *Revue socialiste* 30/177 (1899), 347–71, at 360.

⁴⁶ Rouanet, “Nouveaux brouillards,” 1.

⁴⁷ Georges Sorel, *Le procès de Socrate* (Paris, 1889).

⁴⁸ Barrows, *Distorting Mirrors*, 120–33.

society were necessarily hypnotized by prestigious leaders.⁴⁹ For them, crowd suggestion underpinned the acts of violent crime common in revolutions. In the early 1890s, Sorel read Charcot and other figures who broadly shared his Salpêtrière school's approach, such as Pierre Janet and the German scientist Wilhelm Wundt.⁵⁰ This reading shaped his intervention into the debate on crowd suggestion and criminality: he endorsed the Salpêtrière school view of suggestion as a symptom of a hysterical mental state. Crowd suggestion was not a universal phenomenon but required certain mental preconditions. From 1893, Sorel brought his ideas about Jacobin literature into his account of hysteria and crowd suggestion.

The Boulangist moment was the backdrop for Sorel's 1888–9 study of the Jacobin army and its "revolutionary literature," which consisted of speeches, distributed printed material, and war songs.⁵¹ He himself stressed this context: "these studies are not purely speculative" because "today there are people dishonest enough to deceive the ignorant masses and intoxicate them with a revolutionary epic!"⁵² This was clearly a reference to the legend around Boulanger as a revolutionary figure who would inaugurate a new regime. Sorel also described the Jacobins as "electric patriot[s]" who propagated a bellicose nationalism akin to that of the Boulangists.⁵³ The Jacobin army's revolutionary literature had two components. First, "epithets play a significant role in this low literature": Jacobin officers' speeches, for example, used "expressions such as slaves ... vermin ... [and] scoundrels" to describe France's enemies and inflame soldiers' hatred.⁵⁴ Second, this literature induced feelings of admiration. Jacobin officers "launched into a heroic genre" when describing their future deeds: "we will perish by doing our duty and our death will be glorious."⁵⁵ This was a militarist, nationalist literature of conquest that made Jacobin soldiers admire the fallen as "heroes."⁵⁶ For Sorel, this literature fostered hypnotic suggestion. Through "all the carmagnoles, paraphrases of the Marseillaise ... [and] revolutionary literature ... our fathers' nervous systems were overexcited. The repetition of sonorous phrases, which required no effort of intelligence, caused a numbing of reason and hypnosis."⁵⁷ At this stage, then, Sorel thought repeated regurgitation of legends of heroic, destructive conquest had something to do with hypnotic suggestion. Due to studies in experimental psychology between 1890 and 1895, he developed a view of suggestion which led him to explain Jacobin literature's role in stimulating this phenomenon.

⁴⁹ Ibid., 124.

⁵⁰ See Willy Gianinazzi, "Images mentales et mythe sociale: Psychologie et politique chez Georges Sorel," *Mil neuf cent: Revue d'histoire intellectuelle* 1/28 (2011), 155–72, at 160–63.

⁵¹ Georges Sorel, "Les représentants du peuple à l'Armée des Pyrénées-Orientales," *Revue de la révolution* 13 (1888), 68–153, at 84.

⁵² Ibid., 69.

⁵³ Georges Sorel, "Les Girondins de Roussillon," *Société agricole, scientifique, et littéraire des Pyrénées-Orientales* 30 (1889), 142–224, at 215.

⁵⁴ Ibid., 215.

⁵⁵ Ibid., 220.

⁵⁶ Georges Sorel, "Les représentants du peuple à l'Armée des Pyrénées-Orientales," *Revue de la révolution* 14 (1889), 40–65, at 54.

⁵⁷ Sorel, "Les représentants du peuple" (1888), 84.

Sorel had read Wundt, Charcot, and Janet's scientific works by 1892.⁵⁸ At the same time, he was studying Tarde, Sighele, and Lombroso's analyses of the crowd. He took these thinkers as sharing the Nancy school's perspective that the mass necessarily imitated prestigious leaders and stressed his disagreement with this approach. "Lombroso accepts too easily the conceptions of Sighele, who himself follows Tarde too much ... Sighele admits with Tarde that people follow superior men. History denies this thesis."⁵⁹ Sorel's engagement with the Salpêtrière school led him to hold a more complex view of suggestion: "Charcot established a very important fact, demonstrating that ... magnetism [hypnotic suggestion] consists of an *artificial nervousness* with great affinities to hysteria."⁶⁰ In a review of Janet's *État mental des hystériques* (1892), Sorel discussed the significance of the Salpêtrière school's studies.

Janet, he observed, gave "a definitive formula of hysteria as a form of mental disintegration characterized by the personality's permanent and complete splitting."⁶¹ The hysteric experienced "an order of psychological phenomena independent of consciousness [where] images associate automatically."⁶² A particular kind of education brought about this division of the personality: "nervous training can modify the temperament and fix lower emotional movements ... these movements bring about serious determinations under insignificant causes [by] recalling perceptions."⁶³ Emotional experiences thus agitated the nerves and created a store of images in the unconscious memory. In turn, subsequent emotional disturbances would lead the unconscious to recall these images and disable one's faculty for rational "personal perception."⁶⁴ In Sorel's eyes, Janet's study of hysteria offered a better way to conceptualize suggestion than prevailing views: "it has often been imagined that the suggester only had to command to be obeyed ... suggestion has been much abused; with Janet, we reason about it scientifically. For suggestion to be possible, it is necessary that the automatic association of psychological elements be preserved and the mental synthesis of phenomena be reduced."⁶⁵ Against the crowd psychologists' universalist conception of suggestion, Sorel followed Charcot and Janet: suggestion only worked on hysterics whose unconscious memory regularly recalled automatically associating images.⁶⁶ With this view in hand, Sorel argued Jacobin that militarist literature fostered crowd criminality and suggestion.

⁵⁸ Gianinazzi, "Images mentales et mythe sociale," 160–63. For Sorel's keen interest in Janet see Maddalena Carli and Silvano Montaldo, "Lettres de Georges Sorel à Cesare Lombroso (1893–1895)," *Mil neufcent: Revue d'histoire intellectuelle* 1/36 (2018), 155–82, at 170–75.

⁵⁹ Georges Sorel, "Une faute du crime politique," *Archivio di psichiatria, penali, ed antropologia criminale* 14/5 (1893), 452–4, at 452.

⁶⁰ Georges Sorel, "L'ancienne et la nouvelle métaphysique (suite)," *L'ère nouvelle* 2/5 (1894), 51–87, at 62, added emphasis.

⁶¹ Georges Sorel, "P. Janet, *État mental des hystériques*," *Revue générale des sciences pures et appliquées* 5/1 (1894), 393–4, at 393.

⁶² *Ibid.*, 394.

⁶³ Sorel, "L'ancienne et la nouvelle métaphysique (suite)," 63.

⁶⁴ Sorel, "P. Janet," 394.

⁶⁵ *Ibid.*, 394.

⁶⁶ Wundt shared this view. Wilhelm Wundt, *Hypnotismus und Suggestion* (Leipzig, 1892) 72–5.

The crowd psychologists, such as Lombroso, maintained that crowds were populated by mentally abnormal, crime-prone individuals. Sorel thought there were few “born criminals” in crowds, while another class of criminals—criminaloids—were more important.⁶⁷ These “were very dangerous beings” whose propensity for “crime was prepared over a long time ... and under the influence of strong and repeated excitations.”⁶⁸ Sorel highlighted examples of these excitations: “old popular songs maintain admiration for the bandit. The publicity given to crimes by the press has been reported as a stimulant [*excitant*] and this is true ... in criminaloids’ eyes, he who fights against organized force is great and, if he dies with courage, he is a hero.”⁶⁹ Sorel was describing a Jacobin militarist literature here. The Carmagnole and Marseillaise, after all, were popular war songs. In his mind, repeated exposure to this literature caused degeneration into hysteria. “People of the criminal life,” he contended, “have a weak conscious understanding. Their associations of ideas are very limited. Their mental determinations are almost always linked to some dominating images”—images of past criminals’ heroic violence.⁷⁰ Criminaloids thus existed in a state of constant nervousness, which meant their unconscious memory would regularly overwhelm their rational faculties with such images given emotional agitation. In a review of Le Bon’s *Psychologie des foules* (1895), Sorel specified how the experience of being in a crowd triggered the unconscious.

Sorel read Le Bon as a follower of the Nancy school who failed to give an adequate account of suggestion.⁷¹ He ignored the role of the crowd’s unconscious memory:

Le Bon rightly says, “the heterogeneous drowns in the homogeneous” [in crowds], but he does not give the cause. Emotions always associate with actions using *the material of memories* man possesses. The place of intelligence and voluntary attention is very weak here. The [crowd’s] choice between various actions depends on accidental circumstances ... Le Bon observes that [a leader’s] “example plays an enormous role in crowd suggestion.” I believe this is explained by the fact that this action is closer to emotional expression than speech is.⁷²

Sorel’s point was that a leader’s emotional expression served as the “accidental circumstance” or trigger that shaped crowd behavior by causing the automatic recall of memories from the unconscious.⁷³ Leaders’ “invectives and cries” were expressions of

⁶⁷ Georges Sorel, “La position du problème de Lombroso,” *Revue scientifique* 51/1 (1893), 206–10, at 206, 208–9. On criminaloids’ presence in crowds see Sorel, “Le crime politique d’après Lombroso,” *Revue scientifique* 51/1 (1893), 561–5, at 564.

⁶⁸ Georges Sorel, “Le problème lombrosien et la psychologie physiologique,” *Revue générale des sciences pures et appliquées* 4/19 (1893), 632–8, at 635.

⁶⁹ *Ibid.*, 636.

⁷⁰ Sorel, “La position du problème de Lombroso,” 208.

⁷¹ Georges Sorel, “Le Bon, *Psychologie des foules*,” *Le devenir social* 1/8 (1895), 765–70, at 767–8.

⁷² *Ibid.*, 768–9, added emphasis. The passage cited discussed a leader’s example. For insightful analysis of Sorel’s review see Willy Gianinazzi, “Sorel, lecteur de Le Bon: Huit comptes rendus (1895–1911),” *Mil neuf cent: Revue d’histoire intellectuelle* 1/28 (2010), 121–54, at 121–4.

⁷³ In crowds, “a slight disturbance is enough to stop the functioning of our intellectual faculties because our [mental] images ... are chased away by almost dominating images.” Sorel, “Une faute du crime politique,” 452.

emotion that produced this effect: they inflamed a crowd's hatred towards an enemy deemed responsible for its oppression and called to mind memories associated with this emotion—namely memories of criminals' heroic violence and suffering at the hands of despicable foes.⁷⁴ The recall of such violent images prompted crowd hysterics to experience emotional attacks and lose the ability to consciously direct their attention. They became engrossed with these images: the individual's "mind" in the crowd "was closed to any image not closely linked to the obsession that dominates him."⁷⁵ They embraced a leader's suggestions for violence because, quite literally, they could not think of anything else.

Sorel's engagement with the Salpêtrière school led him to hold a view of crowds similar to that of Rouanet and Fournière. Like them, he thought propaganda stories of heroic, destructive conquest disabled individuals' capacity for voluntary attention such that they became obsessive and suggestible. Yet, due to his reading of Charcot's school, he explained suggestion in a distinct way: it required a state of hysteria in which the unconscious emotional memory overpowered the faculty for rational, conscious thought. Sorel nonetheless stressed his closeness to the independents by praising Rouanet's *Les complicités du Panama* in 1893.⁷⁶ At this stage, however, his theory of the crowd operated on an abstract plane. Although he emphasized a militarist press's role in constructing suggestible crowds, he did not specify the political institutions that were its vehicles. As the Dreyfus affair intensified between 1897 and 1900, Sorel concretized his account of the crowd in analyses of the nationalist and Guesdist movements.

Sorel on crowds and Caesarism during the Dreyfus affair

In the fall of 1897, when Dreyfus's brother publicized the general staff's use of forged evidence in the trial, the Dreyfus affair became a national political crisis. The nationalist press's condemnation of Zola's *J'accuse* in January 1898 and his subsequent conviction for libel demonstrated France's intense polarization over the trial. This polarization influenced the April–May national election.⁷⁷ While Guesde's POF remained noncommittal on Dreyfus's guilt during the election—with some notable candidates outright condemning him—this position effectively aligned the party with the anti-Dreyfusards.⁷⁸ In the tense atmosphere after the publication of *J'accuse*, riotous crowds became a regular sight on Paris's streets. "The Affair," one historian writes, "presented the people in the slumped and corruptible form of the crowd."⁷⁹ These crowds were "small processions of several hundred" that "harassed people considered Jewish,

⁷⁴Sorel, "Le Bon, *Psychologie des foules*" 769. "Public meetings," Sorel wrote elsewhere, were places where "people propagate creative hatred." Georges Sorel, "La douleur universelle," *Revue philosophique* 41 (1896), 204–12, at 206.

⁷⁵Sorel, "Une faute du crime politique," 454.

⁷⁶He endorsed Rouanet's description of a "sophistic" nationalist journalist, Auguste Burdeau. Ibid., 452. Burdeau had covered up scandals by writing "hymns ... to the Fatherland." Rouanet, *Les complicités du Panama*, 212–13. Sorel clearly believed Rouanet shared his view of militarist, nationalist journalism's dangers.

⁷⁷Wilson, *Ideology and Experience*, 16–20.

⁷⁸Ibid., 67, 98.

⁷⁹Prochasson, "Paris au temps de l'affaire Dreyfus," 221.

smashed store windows and hurled abuse at their opponents.”⁸⁰ For Sorel, nationalism and Guesdism created these crowds.

Like the independent socialists, Sorel was concerned with how these revolutionary movements systematically organized and wielded a boulevard press, which had exploded onto the political scene with Boulangism, in their electoral agitation. These movements manifested Jacobin militarist organization and press rhetoric: journalistic general staffs used a centralized press apparatus to disseminate mass propaganda premised on legends of destructive conquest against national enemies. This fashioned hysterical, Caesarist crowds that leaders were likely to use as instruments of terror in reckless palace coups.⁸¹ Sorel’s “independentist” perspective led him to again distinguish his views from those of Le Bon, whose contempt for parliamentary democracy had spurred support for anti-Dreyfusardism: he opposed Le Bon’s anti-Dreyfusard defense of Caesarist crowds’ altruistic, racial instincts advanced in the new *Psychologie du socialisme* (1898). Yet, while Sorel shared the independents’ general orientation, he made the original claim that propaganda legends led crowds to construct an idealized vision of the revolutionary future. This would prompt their murderous fervor in coups.

Much of Sorel’s writing on the affair appeared in Italian journals because he developed relationships and corresponded with Italian sociologists and socialists confronting Caesarist militarism in their own country with the premiership of the general Luigi Pelloux (1898–1900). He also likely felt that an Italian audience would be more receptive to his critique of Jacobin militarism than a French one. Sorel’s most important contacts in Italy were with Guglielmo Ferrero and Napoleone Colajanni, editor of the *Rivista popolare*, where he published.⁸² Ferrero had initiated the debate on Jacobin Caesarism in important lectures in Milan in 1897.⁸³ Sorel thought that his account of Caesarist crowds advanced this debate.

Unsurprisingly, then, Sorel’s first discussion of Caesarism occurred in an 1897 review of Ferrero’s work. Ferrero was right to characterize “Caesarism” as the “true creation of the imaginative and sensual Latin race [which] ... relies on the army ... to maintain an oligarchy.”⁸⁴ In another review from this period, Sorel stressed that an “oligarchy” governed French democracy by creating “fictitious opinion ... [and] enticing men with the abuse of big words.”⁸⁵ This was an oligarchy of journalists whose agitational methods would lead to “the creation of new dynasties beginning with Caesarism.”⁸⁶ Caesarism thus involved journalists manipulating public opinion

⁸⁰Ibid., 230.

⁸¹While Sorel also opposed Guesdism for its dogmatic Marxist scientism, I emphasize a different source of his opposition here.

⁸²See S. Ganci, “I rapporti Sorel-colajanni nella ‘crisi del marxismo’ (1896–1905),” *Annali della Fondazione Feltrinelli* 17 (1976), 191–217, at 212; and M. Simonetti, “Testi e documenti: Georges Sorel e Guglielmo Ferrero fra ‘cesarismo’ borghese e socialismo,” *Il pensiero politico* 5/1 (1972), 102–53, at 134.

⁸³Guglielmo Ferrero, *Il Militarismo: Dieci conferenze* (Milan, 1898), 269–326.

⁸⁴Georges Sorel, “G. Ferrero. *L’Europa giovane*,” *Le devenir social* 3/5 (1897), 459–63, at 460. Written under the pseudonym Jacques David.

⁸⁵Georges Sorel, “*La démocratie*, R. de Kerallain,” *L’humanité nouvelle* 5 (1899), 264.

⁸⁶Ibid.

through grandstanding.⁸⁷ In his examinations of nationalism and Guesdism, Sorel brought these two understandings of Caesarism together: he clarified that Caesarist politics relied on the army not in a direct sense, but because bourgeois journalists embraced army-like structures and militarist imagery to seduce the public.

The nationalist movement's centralized, army-like character became apparent as the affair intensified in 1897–8 and different nationalist groupings overcame disagreements to establish a common front.⁸⁸ “The affair,” Sorel observed, “witnessed the formation of a nationalist party ... a staff [*un personale di uomini*] was created which went to public meetings to agitate. Conservatives finally had at their disposal an army corps [*un arma*].”⁸⁹ For Sorel, the editors Henri Rochefort (*L'Intransigeant*), Édouard Drumont (*La libre parole*), and Ernest Judet (*Le petit journal*) constituted nationalism's bourgeois general staff: “the masses follow journalists who convince them that they think for themselves. The opponents of revision in Dreyfus's trial exploited this feeling ... readers took the reasoning of Judet, Drumont, and Rochefort as gold from a cup.”⁹⁰ These journalists commanded a corps of agitators to disseminate “penny papers [of which] *Le petit journal*” was “the perfect example.”⁹¹ The nationalist press's centralization was evident in the fact that Rochefort's editorial office was next door to that of the leading street hawker, Léon Hayard.⁹²

With mass pamphlets and newspapers, the nationalists bombarded Parisians with legends of destructive conquest that made many lose their ability to direct their attention elsewhere: they entered a state of hysterical obsession. Like the Jacobin army's literature, this press identified national enemies and a national savior. France was witnessing “a renaissance of patriotic and epic legends ... with epithets” presenting Jews as “brutes to be cut with a knife.”⁹³ In turn, the press depicted the army as bearing Jacobinism's mantle and prepared to mete out violence against France's Jewish enemy: the nationalists “live on *traditions* ... and illusions ... whose source lies in the legends of the Revolution and heroic volunteers ... [this was] radical patriotism's historical foundation.”⁹⁴ Nourished by Jacobin chauvinism, the Parisian public “loved and admired the army.”⁹⁵ The problem with the nationalists' “low literature ... of cynical brutality”

⁸⁷ This perspective made Sorel understand Caesarism as more of an enduring threat than Marx. Sorel, “Alcune previsioni storiche di Marx,” 147.

⁸⁸ It is important to note that, due to his already developed worry about the crowd, Sorel overemphasized the extent of nationalist unity. Despite a temporary unity in 1898, divisions prevented the nationalists from creating a single, enduring party. See Joly, *Histoire politique de l'affaire Dreyfus*, 238–40.

⁸⁹ Georges Sorel, “Le elezioni municipali a Parigi,” *Rivista popolare di politica, lettere, e scienze sociali* 6/11 (1900), 208–12, at 208–9.

⁹⁰ Georges Sorel, *Lo spirito pubblico in Francia* (Milan, 1899), 3–4. These newspapers were “effective rallying centers” in the movement. Joly, *Histoire politique de l'affaire Dreyfus*, 238.

⁹¹ Sorel, *Lo spirito pubblico*, 3.

⁹² Mollier, “Zola et la rue,” 80.

⁹³ Georges Sorel, “Sémites et cléricaux,” *La jeunesse socialiste* 1 (1895), 325–8, at 326.

⁹⁴ Georges Sorel, “La nostra inchiesta sulla guerra e sul militarismo,” *La vita internazionale* 1/13 (1898), 310, added emphasis.

⁹⁵ Georges Sorel, “Socialismo e rivoluzione,” *Rivista popolare di politica, lettere, e scienze sociali* 5/1 (1899), 7–9, at 8.

was that it “required no effort of intelligence” from readers.⁹⁶ Instead, it induced intense feelings of hatred and admiration and caused images of the army’s destructive conquest to become seared into Parisians’ memory. Much of the public thus degenerated into hysteria and fixated upon these images. Indeed, Sorel emphasized that the “epidemic ... of [anti-Semitic] nationalism” appealed to “lunatics and epileptics.”⁹⁷ This public’s hysteria ultimately made it form suggestible crowds in the movement. The nationalist party “would not last long,” Sorel insisted, “without the powerful illusions that dominate crowds’ psychology and derive from the *repetition of legends*.”⁹⁸

The POF was also a movement with army-like structures. Since 1882, Guesde had insisted upon a centralized organization in the party and prohibited electoral candidates’ independent initiatives.⁹⁹ After ending his association with Guesdists at *Le devenir social* in 1897, Sorel condemned the POF’s militarized apparatus: “Guesde treats his followers as a Boisdeffre or any general might do ... he only understands authoritarian government.”¹⁰⁰ Such authoritarianism manifested in opposition to discussion about party doctrine. For example, the party newspaper, *Le Socialiste*, was simply a conduit for Guesde’s vulgarizations of Marxism. As one historian notes, “Guesde remained resistant to an open newspaper” that voiced “varied republican and workerist sensibilities.”¹⁰¹ In tune with this analysis, Sorel described Guesde and his confidants as a journalistic general staff. “Guesde and [Paul] Lafargue” were “journalists who claim to judge workers and to understand socialism.”¹⁰² Like the leaders of the Sozialdemokratische Partei Deutschlands (SPD), they constituted a “general staff.”¹⁰³

Guesde directed the POF press to imitate nationalism’s tactics around the 1898 election because he thought appealing to many workers’ nationalist sentiments was necessary for electoral success. Since “the masses have been lectured on the cult of the flag ... and socialists are obliged to seek votes,” Sorel explained, “they mislead the people ... and flatter the stupidities of *Le petit journal*’s readers.”¹⁰⁴ The Guesdists had “become patriots ... authoritarian socialism necessarily leads to nationalism and militarism.”¹⁰⁵ While Sorel did not center the POF press’s anti-Semitism as the independents did, he argued that its mass street literature propagated legends of destructive conquest by portraying socialist revolution as the path to national regeneration.¹⁰⁶ The

⁹⁶Sorel, *Lo spirito pubblico*, 4–5.

⁹⁷ Georges Sorel, “C. Lombroso, *L’Antisémitisme*,” *Revue internationale de sociologie* 7/1 (1899) 301–2, at 301.

⁹⁸Sorel, “La nostra inchiesta,” 310, original emphasis.

⁹⁹Jousse, *Les hommes révoltés*, 107–18, 286–7.

¹⁰⁰ Georges Sorel, “Inchiesta sul socialismo: Dove va il marxismo?,” *Rivista critica del socialismo* 1/1 (1899), 9–21, at 16.

¹⁰¹Jean-Numa Ducange, “Jaurès, Guesde, ‘infiniment plus proches l’un de l’autre qu’on ne l’a cru de leur vivant,” *Cahiers Jaurès* 3/211 (2016), 11–33, at 23.

¹⁰² Georges Sorel, “Democrazia e socialismo: Conclusione sulla faccenda Dreyfus,” *Rivista critica del socialismo* 2/11–12 (1899), 964–81, at 971.

¹⁰³ Georges Sorel, “La social-démocratie allemande,” *Le pays de France* 2/14 (1900), 83–93, 138–46, at 145.

¹⁰⁴ Georges Sorel, “Enquête sur la guerre et le militarisme,” *L’humanité nouvelle* 1 suppl. (1899), 117–19, at 117.

¹⁰⁵*Ibid.*, 118.

¹⁰⁶On the Guesdists’ mass brochures see Mollier, “La ‘littérature du trottoir,’” 5.

Guesdists' *Le Socialiste* "reasoned like Judet [*Le petit journal*]" because it demonized a national enemy and apotheosized a national savior.¹⁰⁷ Guesdist propaganda consequently weakened workers' capacity to control and direct their attention to objects of their choosing; it made them hysterically obsessive.

Ernest-Antoine Seillière's book *Littérature et morale dans le parti socialiste allemande* (1898) led Sorel to focus on demonizing socialist propaganda. Although this book was nominally about the SPD, Sorel thought its examples of propaganda literature represented the "corruption disseminated by [socialist] politicians" generally.¹⁰⁸ Seillière had described a story published in the SPD's illustrated Sunday magazine that followed the travails of an impoverished working-class woman, Bertha, who had to sell herself to a "charlatan doctor" in return for medicine for her terminally ill child.¹⁰⁹ For Sorel, the problem with this story was that it presented capitalists, whom the venal doctor embodied, in the same way as nationalist propaganda portrayed Jews: as "enemies living a bestial life" who deserved repression.¹¹⁰ It sought to enrage workers and stir their desire to avenge Bertha, who had committed suicide when her child died. By creating a symbolic target for socialist hatred and conquest, demonizing stories like this one exemplified the Guesdists' "idiotic" street literature.¹¹¹

Equally important, the POF press circulated pamphlets that depicted Guesde as a national savior who would lead a revolutionary war of conquest. Sorel pointed to a popular brochure in which "we learn that our soldiers have been Guesde's constant preoccupation because he believes our country will play a great role in the next revolution and wants an invincible France ... he dreams of carrying the revolutionary flag to neighboring countries as in 1794."¹¹² In a published speech, Guesde also intimated that he would create "a true homeland after the social revolution."¹¹³ This mass propaganda led workers to see Guesde as an armed protector whose revolutionary conquest would liquidate capitalists at home and establish national unity. Since this propaganda induced intense feelings of hatred and admiration, it became imprinted on workers' unconscious memory. This caused them to degenerate into hysteria and form suggestible crowds: Guesdists were "dominated ... by memories of 1793," which meant they regularly recalled images of Guesde as a Jacobin conqueror and fixated upon him.¹¹⁴

Nationalist and Guesdist crowds' obsessive state led them to construct an idealized vision of the revolutionary future: the overthrow of the republic would proceed

¹⁰⁷ Georges Sorel, "Il socialismo e la teoria delle razze," *Rivista critica del socialismo* 2/7 (1899), 577–86, at 586. Written under the pseudonym Jacques David. The Guesdists indeed used portraits of "heroic figures as examples to follow." Ducange, *Jules Guesde*, 26–7.

¹⁰⁸ Sorel, "Dove va il marxismo?," 18.

¹⁰⁹ Ernest-Antoine Seillière, *Littérature et morale dans le parti socialiste allemande* (Paris, 1898), 271–2.

¹¹⁰ Georges Sorel, "Littérature et morale dans le parti socialiste allemande, E. Seillière," *L'humanité nouvelle* 4 (1899), 267–8, at 268.

¹¹¹ Sorel, "Il socialismo e la teoria delle razze," 586.

¹¹² Sorel, "Le elezioni municipali," 209.

¹¹³ Sorel, "Enquête sur la guerre," 118.

¹¹⁴ Georges Sorel, "La crise du socialisme," *Revue politique et parlementaire* 18/54 (1898), 598–612, at 603.

exactly as propaganda legends suggested. As Sorel explained, “in crowds we *automatically* try to *repeat* what we believe to have been good in the past.”¹¹⁵ The emotional attacks induced by the recall of these legends untethered crowd members’ vision of the future from reality: “when emotion extinguishes individuals’ faculty of measurement ... everything which smiles on their imagination is possible ... social relations can become anything by the use of force.”¹¹⁶ For Sorel, the Guesdist proletariat was not simply an inert mass that waited for capitalist crisis to produce revolution.¹¹⁷ Instead, it was a hysterical mass that would seek to violently accelerate into a revolution which it imagined to mirror those of the past.¹¹⁸ Against the Guesdists, he stressed that “we should never imagine the working class’s future from memories of old revolutions.”¹¹⁹

While Sorel certainly worried that crowds would unthinkingly vote for nationalism and Guesdism, then, he also fundamentally emphasized their potential to facilitate the violent establishment of revolutionary dictatorship. In reviews of Le Bon’s *Psychologie du socialisme*, he made this clear: he endorsed Le Bon’s description of crowds as Caesarist, while rejecting Le Bon’s anti-Dreyfusard positive view of them. Sorel highlighted the “seriousness” of Le Bon’s “thesis that socialism and democracy are in danger of perishing because crowds are conservative and will follow the daring adventurer or obey the oligarchy who has the energy to command them.”¹²⁰ Yet he opposed Le Bon’s “praise of the masses” for “instinctively defending the country’s interests.”¹²¹ Le Bon had characterized crowds as possessing instinctual “altruism” that made them only engage in “occasional ephemeral violence” and acclaim “the first Caesar who promised to restore what they had broken.”¹²² Crowds’ embrace of restorative Caesar would “maintain a race’s collective interests.”¹²³ Sorel disagreed:

I cannot share Le Bon’s admiration for the masses’ instincts ... they only know about social interests, the homeland, and politics from what the most vulgar agitators teach them ... the mass is careless, boastful, and fierce ... Le Bon believes that crowds will crush socialism and democracy because they support dictatorship ... Recent events [the 1898 election] have shown that, for elected representatives, Truth, Justice, and Morality do not count for much ... but are these not higher ideals than that of crowds “turning towards a Caesar’s plume?”¹²⁴

¹¹⁵Sorel, “La nostra inchiesta,” 310, added emphasis.

¹¹⁶Georges Sorel, “Les aspects juridiques du socialisme,” *Revue socialiste* 32/190 (1900), 385–415, at 393.

¹¹⁷On the independents’ critique of the Guesdists’ distant revolution see Wright, *Socialism and the Experience of Time*, 22–3, 85.

¹¹⁸The Guesdists, Prochasson rightly notes, sought a “rupture with the present in the mirror of past revolutions.” Prochasson, “Nouveaux regards sur le réformisme,” 11.

¹¹⁹Georges Sorel, “Les facteurs moraux de l’évolution,” in Gustave Belot, ed., *Questions de morale* (Paris, 1900), 74–100, at 92.

¹²⁰Georges Sorel, “Le Bon, *Psychologie du socialisme*,” *Le mouvement socialiste* 1/5 (1899), 316–17, at 316.

¹²¹*Ibid.*, 317.

¹²²Gustave Le Bon, *Psychologie du socialisme* (Paris, 1898), 119–21.

¹²³*Ibid.*, 120.

¹²⁴Georges Sorel, “G. Le Bon, *Psychologie du socialisme*,” *Revue internationale de sociologie* 7/1 (1899), 152–5, at 154. Sorel later emphasized that there was “a good deal of truth” in Le Bon’s claim that crowds “always go to a Caesar.” Georges Sorel, *Réflexions sur la violence* (Paris, 1908), 103.

Le Bon thus ignored how vulgar journalist agitators influenced crowds' instincts. The 1898 election had shown that nationalism and Guesdism's boulevard journalism created "careless, boastful, and fierce" crowds which fixated upon a Caesar's plume. Against Le Bon's "ideal" of Caesarist crowds as altruistic forces, Sorel maintained they would be agents of Jacobin terror in a nationalist or Guesdist coup attempt. This perspective led him to warn in 1898 that "France was moving towards Caesarism."¹²⁵

Nationalist and Guesdist leaders posed the threat of an amateurish palace coup rather than a Blanquist coup. While the socialist followers of Auguste Blanqui in nineteenth-century France had defended the need for a trained vanguard to confront the army on the barricades during coup attempts, a palace coup involved conspirators seizing government buildings at the time of political uncertainty. "I cannot see Guesde," Sorel explained, "at the head of armed workers marching against the troops ... he has always counted on political crises [and] seeks to exercise his party's revolutionary action on an almost unarmed, Girondian government."¹²⁶ While nationalist agitators were "reckless" and had "the idea of a coup," they too were "pretenders [who] had no inclination for a serious fight."¹²⁷ For Sorel, hysterical crowds were ill-suited to organized barricade combat. Instead, nationalist or Guesdist adventurers were more likely to take advantage of a government crisis to direct their "careless" crowds to violently occupy the Palais Bourbon. Even if a coup failed to bring regime change, Sorel thought it would involve murderous chaos and produce temporary Parisian dictatorship.¹²⁸

In the late 1890s, Sorel invested his hopes in the *bourses du travail* because he thought that these institutions were bringing into being a socialist culture different from that of Guesdism. This was a culture free of Jacobinism and all this entailed: militarist boulevard presses, Caesarist adventurism, and violent crowds. For Sorel, socialist education in the *bourses* developed workers' rational faculties rather than inflaming their passions of hatred and admiration. In pushing this view, he showed his socialist colors. Unlike such liberals as Alfred Fouillée and Charles Renouvier, Sorel did not think that workers were destined for subordination to elites in the economy and democracy.¹²⁹ Instead, they could achieve self-government in the present through the right kind of media and educational institutions. Such self-government would involve workers' exercise of independent influence over their local economies and parliament.

¹²⁵ Georges Sorel, "Lettere di Sorel a Lagardelle: 15 agosto 1898," in R. Ragghianti, ed., *Considerazioni politiche e filosofiche* (Milan, 1982), 131–2, at 132.

¹²⁶ Sorel, "Socialismo e rivoluzione," 7.

¹²⁷ Sorel, "Le elezioni municipali," 210.

¹²⁸ In letter to Ferrero in October 1898, Sorel explicitly warned of a coup. Simonetti, "Testi e documenti," 140.

¹²⁹ On these figures see Pierre Rosanvallon, *La démocratie inachevée: Histoire de la souveraineté du peuple en France* (Paris, 2000), 254.

Sorel's antidote to Caesarist crowds: socialist education in the *bourses du travail*

My analysis of Sorel's anxieties about the crowd offers a new way to grasp his vision of the *bourses'* educational tasks and, in turn, the conditions under which a present-minded, democratic socialism could emerge. Like the independent socialists, Sorel turned to unions and cooperatives as institutions that enabled workers to pursue the moral and cultural change required for socialism "in the near future."¹³⁰ Education in the *bourses*, he believed, immunized workers from crowds' hysteria and projection into an idealized revolutionary future.¹³¹ This was because these institutions created a new media sphere that led workers to consciously direct their attention to practical and material matters vital to their economic emancipation: understanding production, improving their immediate surroundings, and forming cooperative relationships with their comrades. In short, *bourse* unionists developed a socialist culture of attentive reflection which was manifest in what Sorel labelled their democratic legal spirit: through inclusive, democratic discussion about their local economy, unionists established rules to govern their cooperative self-government in industry.¹³²

In the early 1890s, the *bourses* developed as an alternative to other unions—namely the *unions de métiers*, which were associations of workers within a profession, and the Fédération des syndicats, which was a federation of unions that attached itself to the POF. In 1892, twelve *bourses* emerged across France when local unions from across different professions established spaces for the study of a region's economy. They created these spaces in two ways. First, the *bourses* conducted surveys of local production and consumption. In regular conferences, moreover, workers discussed how to manage production more cooperatively and scientifically. The *bourses* held courses in mathematics, physical sciences, and technology to enable workers to comprehend economic surveys and participate in the conferences.¹³³ They also encouraged workers to attend lectures at the *universités populaires*, established in 1899.¹³⁴ Second, each *bourse* founded a newspaper to report on survey results, conferences, and production issues. The federation established a newspaper, *Louvrier des deux mondes*, in 1897. These newspapers were radically different from nationalist and Guesdist outlets. As the leading *bourse* organizer Fernand Pelloutier wrote, "there is little taste for serious reading in France. The worker reads the patriotic, saber press. [With *Louvrier des deux mondes*] we introduced into the press an absolutely new journal ... an economic information manual."¹³⁵

¹³⁰Wright, *Socialism and the Experience of Time*, 23. For discussion of the independents' visions of present-minded socialism see *ibid.*, 60–62, 84–90, 131–76.

¹³¹On nonparty socialist education at this time see Prochasson, *Le socialisme, une culture*, 36–44; and Brandom, "Against the Hierarchy of Knowledge," 53–70.

¹³²This "legal spirit" was similar to the independents' "ethic of discussion." See Jousse, *Les hommes révoltés*, 381–8.

¹³³Jacques Julliard, *Fernand Pelloutier et les origines du syndicalisme d'action directe* (Paris, 1971), 243–9.

¹³⁴Brandom, "Against the Hierarchy of Knowledge," 11.

¹³⁵Fernand Pelloutier, "Aux Bourses du travail," *Le monde ouvrier* 2/6 (1899), 81–2. On proletarian journalism at this time see Xavier Vigna, "Les mains calleuses pour des lettres nouvelles? Les écritures ouvrières en France à l'orée du xx siècle," *Mil neuf cent: Revue d'histoire intellectuelle* 1/35 (2017), 61–79.

Sorel was well aware of these developments and, between 1898 and 1902, repeatedly highlighted the *bourses* as places where workers pursued the practical study of their economic environment. “Anarchist unionists ... [in] the *Bourses du travail*,” he wrote in 1898, “study ... practical life.”¹³⁶ He recognized the *bourses’* press as central to their endeavors. “I cannot recommend reading *Le monde ouvrier* enough,” he declared, because “it contains detailed studies on practical questions.”¹³⁷ Indeed, *bourse* unionists’ reading habits made them unique: “there are perhaps 20,000 anarchists in France ... many enter unions ... because of their love for education they differ greatly from socialists who barely read.”¹³⁸ In a crucial essay from 1900, Sorel specified how education in economic institutions like the *bourses* cultivated a socialist culture of attentive reflection.

In this essay, he contrasted economic education with a deficient approach that he thought existed in public schools and political campaigns. The latter involved “passing before pupils pictures of the idealized history of a few superior individuals.”¹³⁹ This education “furnishes our memory with images [such that] we can never take any action without memories immediately appearing and provoking a comparison.”¹⁴⁰ The nationalist and Guesdist presses’ stories of heroic conquerors “educated” workers in this manner. In contrast, institutions like the *bourses*

bring about a personal, active, and permanent experience which makes us understand the power we have over the world, indicates to us how we should modify human relations, and enables us to judge events that affect us ... economic institutions clip the wings of idealism ... the obstacles to be overcome lie not so much outside as inside ourselves: we have stiff necks and do not want to submit to reason.¹⁴¹

By developing workers’ capacity to judge their economic environment, the *bourses* enabled them to confront *internal psychological* obstacles to practical economic action. The *bourses* therefore “clipped the wings of idealism” because they prevented workers from becoming engrossed with propaganda stories of destructive conquest and Caesar savior figures. Workers came to see these stories—and idealized visions of the revolutionary future constructed on their basis—as distractions from the practical matters essential for economic emancipation. Instead, they concentrated their attention on understanding production’s scientific technicalities so that they could improve its processes and establish cooperative relationships with each other. “We must continually appeal to ... the understanding,” Sorel emphasized, “to curb our visions and control the exercise of our faculties of invention.”¹⁴²

¹³⁶ Sorel, “La crise du socialisme,” 610.

¹³⁷ Georges Sorel, “Rivista dei periodici: *Le monde ouvrier*,” *Rivista critica del socialismo* 1/6 (1899), 556–7 at 556. *Le monde ouvrier* was the new title of the federation’s newspaper.

¹³⁸ Sorel, *Lo spirito pubblico*, 6.

¹³⁹ Sorel, “Les facteurs moraux de l’évolution,” 97.

¹⁴⁰ *Ibid.*, 97.

¹⁴¹ *Ibid.*, 97–100.

¹⁴² Georges Sorel, “Économie et agriculture,” *Revue socialiste* 33/195 (1901), 289–302, at 297–8.

The *bourse* proletariat's culture of attentive reflection generated a democratic legal spirit: "under the influence of practice (cooperation, mutuality), the legal spirit begins to take on considerable importance ... we have gone from vague hypotheses to the reasoned elaboration of principles ... [from] emotional darkness to the clarity of legal discussions."¹⁴³ By "legal spirit," Sorel meant how workers discussed and formulated rules to organize their economic life in a cooperative and scientific manner. At this time, he connected the positive side of democracy to local practices of discussion that fostered intellectual independence. He was clearest on this point in 1901: "in democracy, institutions must produce the liberty to think spontaneously ... it is worth examining the means employed to defend this liberty ... [such as] the federalist organization of education."¹⁴⁴ Sorel had the *bourses* in mind here. As a result of its attentive "legal spirit," the *bourse* proletariat held a particular view of the relationship between the present and socialist future.

If the Guesdist crowd sought to escape the present and violently accelerate into an idealized socialist future, the *bourse* unionists believed that the socialist future would emerge out of ordinary acts in the present. "Anarchists," Sorel observed, "construct a personal conception of the future and carry out the individual acts that it entails ... [they manifest] a practical spirit that gives well-determined meaning to what happens in the future."¹⁴⁵ Thus, among the *bourse* proletariat, "socialism no longer exists in a symbolic future, but in the present: utopias are replaced with hypotheses capable of being acted upon in practice."¹⁴⁶ These unionists continually modified their actions "with a view to self-government," which meant they seized upon present opportunities to practice cooperative decision making in their local economic contexts.¹⁴⁷

The *bourse* proletariat's attentive culture ultimately led it to shun the POE, its propaganda legends, and Caesarist crowds. As Sorel put it, "[French] worker associations seem, for some time now, to be emancipating themselves from Parisian trouble-making bands."¹⁴⁸ If workers had previously been "led by socialist publicists and orators' hot-blooded pronouncements," unionists were "regaining their independence" through the "*Bourses du travail*."¹⁴⁹ In his mind, the *bourses'* culture had decisive political consequences during the Dreyfus affair. He specifically highlighted the political activism of the Allemanist group within the *bourses*. These largely Parisian unionists had taken up leading positions in the Parisian *bourse* and played an integral role in the national federation's formation in the 1890s.¹⁵⁰ They practiced a type of street protest, Sorel argued, that combated the Caesarist threat and influenced parliamentary representatives to take measures to support their self-government in industry.

¹⁴³ Sorel, "Les aspects juridiques du socialisme," 393.

¹⁴⁴ Georges Sorel, *Essai sur l'église et l'état* (Paris, 1901), 58.

¹⁴⁵ Sorel, "Les aspects juridiques du socialisme," 398.

¹⁴⁶ Sorel, "Democrazia e socialismo," 974.

¹⁴⁷ Sorel, "Les facteurs moraux de l'évolution," 100.

¹⁴⁸ Sorel, "Socialismo e rivoluzione," 8.

¹⁴⁹ Georges Sorel, "L. de Seilhac, *I congressi operai in Francia*," *Rivista critica del socialismo* 1/6 (1899), 561–2, at 562.

¹⁵⁰ Julliard, *Fernand Pelloutier*, 114–15.

The Allemanists and Sorel's vision of working-class street action

During the affair's critical period between 1898 and 1900, independent and Dreyfusard socialists were anxious to distinguish between dangerous crowds and dignified, beneficial street movements. Rouanet, the professor Charles Andler, and the poet Charles Péguy, who had socialist sympathies at this time, all located a countermodel of street protest in the mass Dreyfusard demonstrations on 12 June and 19 November 1899.¹⁵¹ The latter event involved 300,000 socialists and republicans who peacefully marched to the Place de la Nation to profess support for the democratic republic. These two demonstrations' "courteous calm" differentiated them from the crowds dominating Paris's streets.¹⁵² Sorel also established a contrast between calm street protest and violent crowds, but he did not view the mass Dreyfusard demonstrations as representing the former.¹⁵³ He endorsed the Allemanist marches because only this kind of street movement manifested a socialist culture of attentive, present-minded action.

In his view, the Allemanists' clear, hymn-like chanting activated other republican citizens' rational faculties: it did so by concentrating their attention on the Caesarist threat gripping the republic and its democratic, socialist alternative. By gaining republican citizens' support, Sorel thought the Allemanist marches were part of an anti-Caesarist political strategy: they deterred crowds' rule over the street and prevented coups.¹⁵⁴ Equally important, they facilitated unionists' independent influence over parliament: they contributed to the formation of a republican–socialist coalition and inspired a new kind of socialist representation committed to passing reforms beneficial to union self-government. For Sorel, the Allemanists inspired the independent socialist Alexandre Millerand, who entered the cabinet as minister of commerce in 1899, to bear their culture in his representative conduct.

In an 1899 essay, Sorel highlighted an Allemanist march that dissolved a Caesarist crowd and helped to thwart a coup: "in August, anarchists came to the Place de la République to prevent an anti-Semitic demonstration. The latter did not take place [because] about 2,000 people walked between the Place de la République and Place de la Nation ... *pronunciamentos* [coups] are now possible ... the current tranquility of the street is a great safeguard against militarist attacks."¹⁵⁵ While Sorel did not specify here how the march dissolved the anti-Semitic crowd, Jean Allemane's discussion of another march in Rennes suggests a method. "Our comrades in Rennes," Allemane explained, "stood up to the terrorizing ... militarist bands mobilized in view of Dreyfus's upcoming trial. Thanks to our comrades' energy, all the republican citizens of Rennes were soon on their feet, and, at the reactionaries' first attacks, they rushed

¹⁵¹ Gustave Rouanet, "La journée de Longchamps," *La petite provençal* 24/8186 (1899), 1; see Andler's retrospective discussion in Charles Andler, *Vie de Lucien Herr* (Paris, 1932), 144–5; Charles Péguy, "Le triomphe de la République," *Cahiers de la quinzaine* 1/1 (1900), 24–48.

¹⁵² Péguy, "Le triomphe de la République," 43.

¹⁵³ He described these demonstrations as unnecessarily provocative. Sorel, *Lo spirito pubblico*, 6–7.

¹⁵⁴ This analysis of Sorel's socialist Dreyfusardism supplements Jennings's claim that it rested on his opposition to the exercise of arbitrary power in Dreyfus's trial. Jennings, *Georges Sorel*, 87.

¹⁵⁵ Sorel, *Lo spirito pubblico*, 8. For his explicit endorsement of the "Allemanists" and their street actions as crucial to "defend[ing] the democratic republic" see Georges Sorel, "Les dissensions de la social-démocratie allemande," *Revue politique et parlementaire* 25/73 (1900), 33–66, at 36.

upon them and took away their clubs.”¹⁵⁶ The Allemanists’ street action disbanded the nationalist crowd, then, because it influenced onlookers to join their side. There was an initial confrontation, but the crowd gave up its willingness to fight in the face of the joint Allemanist–republican front. The August march that Sorel referenced likely proceeded in the same manner: it began with a smaller number of Allemanists and then expanded to 2,000 people as more republican citizens joined. This was what caused the nationalist crowd to shrink away.

The Allemanist marches brought republican citizens onto their side because they clearly communicated the nature of the Caesarist threat. As Allemane put it, “our protestors’ voices have produced an awakening in cities [by] tearing off the mask of anti-Semitism and revealing its lying face.”¹⁵⁷ The Allemanists’ speech distinguished their marches from Caesarist crowds. Nothing here was akin to the incendiary shrieking that adventurers used to make crowds recall propaganda images of destructive conquest, experience emotional delirium, and blindly imitate them. “Harangues,” Allemane stressed, “do little for the people’s education.”¹⁵⁸ In contrast, the Allemanist marches—as Péguy explained in a discussion of one—involved a “slow and sweeping singing, like a canticle.”¹⁵⁹ The Allemanists’ steady, clear, and calm speech thus prompted republican bystanders to voluntarily direct their attention to the Caesarist threat. As a result, these citizens rationally endorsed the need to form a front against it and *emulated* the Allemanists by joining them on the street. Since this was conscious and rational rather than blindly emotive emulation, it was not a case of hysterical suggestion.

Sorel’s discussions of Dreyfusard street action suggest that he viewed the Allemanist marches in this light. “Dreyfusard campaigning,” like that of the marches, weakened rather than strengthened “the militarists.”¹⁶⁰ If initially “the extremists had moderates [i.e. republican bystanders] as their auxiliaries,” then Dreyfusard agitation exposed the militarists’ aims.¹⁶¹ “The stone that now exists in the reactionary movement’s gears,” Sorel declared, “*forces the blind* to become aware of [*accorgersi*] its existence” and violent intentions.¹⁶² Like Allemane, Sorel thought the Allemanist marches represented a working-class street action that rationally enlightened rather than emotionally stupefied participants and onlookers. He further claimed that these marches promoted democratic, socialist progress because their consciousness-raising effects helped to

¹⁵⁶ Jean Allemane, “Le parti a Rennes,” *Le Parti ouvrier* 11/1532 (1899), 1.

¹⁵⁷ Jean Allemane, “Où en sommes nous?” *Le Parti ouvrier* 11/1500 (1899), 1.

¹⁵⁸ Jean Allemane, “La semaine,” *Le Parti ouvrier* 11/1549 (1899), 1. Here, Allemane described his comrades’ participation in the November demonstration. Although Sorel criticized this demonstration, he believed the Allemanist element was its most educative part.

¹⁵⁹ Péguy, “Le triomphe de la République,” 44. Péguy stressed the Allemanists’ calming effect on other participants in the demonstration: when the Allemanists arrived at the Place de la Nation, the “provocative ... Carmagnole died down.” *Ibid.*, 44.

¹⁶⁰ Sorel, “Lettere di Sorel a Lagardelle: 15 agosto 1898,” 132.

¹⁶¹ *Ibid.*

¹⁶² *Ibid.*, added emphasis.

form a republican–socialist coalitional government. “Millerand’s entry into the ministry,” Sorel explained, “was the natural consequence of ... rapprochements between democrats, socialists, and anarchists” in Dreyfusard agitation.¹⁶³

In Sorel’s telling, the Allemanist marches inspired Millerand to bear their socialist attitude in his conduct as minister. Millerand was, in fact, exceptionally attentive to workers’ local situations and their specific demands for state intervention.¹⁶⁴ Indeed, Sorel drew a distinction between “true [socialist] political action and politicians’ agitation” in light of the Allemanists’ influence on Millerand: “the former’s aim is to make public opinion favorable to workers’ demands. This is easier the more one abandons revolutionary, apocalyptic sermons ... it is useful to have the proletariat’s authoritative representatives in the Chamber—men who know workers’ practical issues and can advance factual arguments. The socialist [parliamentary] group should be serious, instill respect, and include competent people.”¹⁶⁵

Just as the Allemanist marches activated republican citizens’ rational faculties, Millerand did so through his interventions in parliament and cabinet meetings: specifically, he directed his republican colleagues’ attention to the need to pass legislation that would facilitate workers’ organization and devolve regulatory power to unions. Workers were ultimately “happy to see Millerand in the Ministry” because he “fought against central powers” and supported their “federation [in] groups.”¹⁶⁶

This defense of Millerand was short-lived. By late 1901, Sorel no longer viewed Millerand as a new socialist representative. He changed his position in light of Millerand’s proposal to establish compulsory work councils, which the *bourses* rejected. The councils would inevitably fall under demagogues’ influence as they sought to dictate strike outcomes for political gain.¹⁶⁷ Sorel’s disillusionment, however, should not diminish the significance of his initial view. Between 1899 and 1901, he believed that the Allemanists and Millerand offered a way out of a political atmosphere asphyxiated by militarist journalism, Caesarist adventurism, and violent crowds.

Conclusion

This article has examined Sorel’s theory of the crowd in the 1890s and its influence on his early socialist vision. I have argued that his engagement with the Salpêtrière school of psychology and reflections on the Dreyfus affair led him to differentiate between subservient crowd movements and positive, autonomous working-class organization. He made this core distinction by associating each of these phenomena with unique media environments, which cultivated certain mental habits among workers, and different political forms of the socialist movement. In developing his argument against crowd-based socialism, Sorel contributed in an innovative way to the independent

¹⁶³ Georges Sorel, “Préface,” in Napoleone Colajanni, *Le socialisme* (Paris, 1900), i–xxi, at ii–iii.

¹⁶⁴ Jousse, *Les hommes révoltés*, 244–52.

¹⁶⁵ Sorel, “Dove va il marxismo?,” 21.

¹⁶⁶ Sorel, “Democrazia e socialismo,” 980, 978.

¹⁶⁷ Michael Prat and Georges Sorel, “Lettres de Georges Sorel à Eduard Bernstein (1898–1902),” *Mil neuf cent: Revue d’histoire intellectuelle* 10/11 (1993), 141–97, at 191.

socialists'—Gustave Rouanet and Eugène Fournière's—challenge to Guesdism and its political vehicle, the Parti ouvrier français.

Like these figures, Sorel was concerned with the emergence of a demagogic socialism in France that, instead of investing in workers' self-governing capacities, transformed them into a manipulable mass. This type of socialism, he warned, would only advance bourgeois, Jacobin party leaders' interest in consolidating power in their hands rather than workers' economic emancipation. During the Dreyfus affair, Sorel came to think that Guesdism represented this socialism because Guesdists' militarist press propaganda, borrowed from nationalism, fueled the rise of hysterical, suggestible crowds in the movement. This generated Guesdism's authoritarian and Caesarist political form: dominated by propaganda images recalled by their subconscious memory, hysterical workers in crowds would experience emotional attacks, acclaim Guesde as a Caesar-like military savior, and obey his suggestions for coup terror. For Sorel, the symbolic representation that a Caesar figure offered workers was a harmful illusion: it came at the expense of their intellectual and political autonomy in democracy and, potentially, also their lives.

The *bourses du travail*, Sorel argued, established a very different kind of media environment. In contrast to the Guesdist press's phantasmic, saber-rattling visions of revolution, the *bourses'* press centered studies of local economies, union conference discussions, and technological developments in production. This media's rigorous analyses of material reality and practical science led unionists to develop habits of attentive reflection, critical observation, and judgment. In Sorel's view, these unionists' intellectual and moral culture lay at the root of their socialism's democratic form and present-minded, reformist agenda. A democratic, reformist orientation was evident not only in their local practices of deliberation to determine cooperative reforms to production, but also in their communicative, coalition-building street action. The Allemanist unionists' disciplined marches in defense of the republic between 1898 and 1900, Sorel thought, embodied a new kind of socialist street politics far more amenable to progress toward workers' economic self-government than crowd paroxysms.

This account of the early Sorel suggests productive new ways to read his *Réflexions sur la violence*. While he famously embraced revolutionary syndicalism and rejected unions' interactions with parliamentary democracy in 1903, his opposition to a Jacobin socialism premised on the militarist conquest of state power and crowd terror remained unchanged.¹⁶⁸ If syndicalists' violent strikes were not hysterical, hateful, and blindly obedient crowd movements, it is worth exploring their resonances with the Allemanist marches: we might consider how their strike violence activated nonaligned workers' emotions in a manner conducive to a rational understanding of the value of socialist self-government.¹⁶⁹

Sorel's analyses also offer insights into the pathologies of our digital, social-media-facilitated democracy. The attack on the United States Capitol on 6 January 2021, for example, was a crowd movement driven by an alt-right media environment that manifested Make America Great Again's authoritarian proclivities. What Sorel draws

¹⁶⁸ He condemned party socialists' war of conquest. Sorel, *Réflexions sur la violence*, 145–6.

¹⁶⁹ Hatred and revenge did not motivate syndicalist strikes. Sorel, *Réflexions sur la violence*, 80–81.

our attention to in this event—and others like it—is the connection between citizens' exposure to repeated sloganeering in the media, crowds' emotional identification with incendiary leaders, and their embrace of violence. From Sorel's perspective, a media landscape, like that of the alt-right meme sphere, which inundates viewers with images glorifying a militarist attitude and political violence, empowers the subconscious emotional memory at the expense of rational, discriminating thought.¹⁷⁰ The inhabitant of this alt-right media space, a Sorelian account would suggest, is likely to uncritically identify with a rabble-rousing leader calling for violence because his subconscious memory makes him emotionally obsessed with cartoonish, meme-framed combat against political opponents.

From Sorel's study of the *bourses du travail*, we can draw out the outlines of a different future for our digital democracy. His thinking suggests that unions can play a leading role in establishing a novel media environment distinct from one saturated with attention-grabbing meme imagery and vitriolic slogans. Unions, for example, could serve as sites for the emergence of worker-owned, nonprofit media platforms focused on thorough local and national economic reporting.¹⁷¹ With Sorel, we might anticipate this media space to foster workers' practices of directed attention, critical and informed discussion on union strategy, and tolerant disagreement. It could also encourage their democratic, coalition-building—rather than authoritarian—street action. At a time of union revival, then, Sorel points us toward a vision of unions as institutions that enable workers' attentive participation and independent influence in democracy.

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¹⁷⁰For an insightful discussion of alt-right memes' militarist themes see Julia R. DeCook, "Memes and Symbolic Violence: #proudboys and the Use of Memes for Propaganda and the Construction of Collective Identity," *Learning, Media, and Technology* 43/4 (2018), 485–504.

¹⁷¹On nonprofit media platforms see Julia Cagé, *Saving the Media: Capitalism, Crowdfunding, and Democracy*, trans. Arthur Goldhammer (Cambridge, 2016).

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